

CENTRAL ASIA

CENTRAL ASIA LIES FAR FROM the world's oceans. The winds are dry and there is little rainfall, so the area is generally arid. With cold, dry winters, and hot, dry summers, lack of water is a problem for farmers. The north consists of a flat, grass-covered plain, or steppe. In the center of the region are two vast deserts, the Kyzyl Kum ("Red Sands") and the Kara Kum ("Black Sands"). In the south are long chains of snowcapped mountain ranges that join the neighboring Himalayas. The entire region, aside from Afghanistan, used to be part of the Soviet Union. Industrialization and collective farms brought huge changes to a region once occupied mainly by nomads.



Nomadic herders in the hills of Afghanistan

NOMADIC LIFESTYLE

Many people living in central Asia are nomads, moving from place to place with their animals in search of new pastures. Nomads live in tents and have few belongings, making traveling easy and quick. They live by herding animals such as camels, goats, and sheep, which give them milk, meat, and wool, some of which they sell, but most of which they use themselves. Nomads mostly stay in the open country, but they visit the towns and cities occasionally to sell their products.

DRILLING FOR OIL

The northern states of central Asia are sitting on huge reserves of oil and gas. Kazakhstan is slowly exploiting one of the world's biggest oil fields under the Caspian Sea, while Turkmenistan is beginning to make use of a vast reservoir of natural gas trapped beneath its land. Exploitation of these riches is hampered by lack of investment and a poorly skilled workforce.



Miners drilling for oil in the Tengiz oil field in Kazakhstan



INDEPENDENCE

In 1991, the communist state of the Soviet Union fell apart and the central Asian countries became independent. While the countries were under Soviet rule, many Russian people settled there, and Russian replaced the local languages. Today, the peoples of central Asia have reestablished their own languages and national identities.



Child's hat from Afghanistan



This girl's hat from Uzbekistan is embroidered with gold thread.

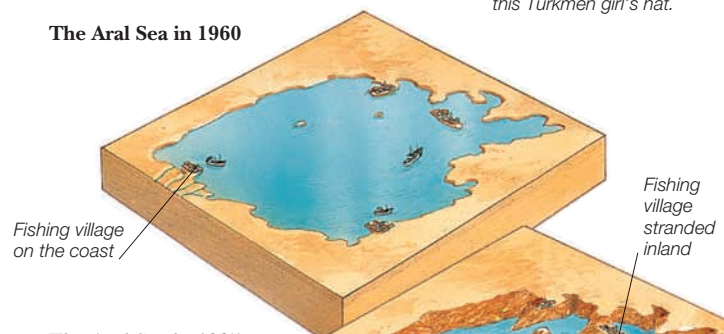
A LAND OF MANY PEOPLES

There is a great variety of people living in central Asia. The original inhabitants include the Kazakhs, Turkmens, and Uzbeks, related to the Turks, and the Tajiks and Afghans, related to the Iranians. Each group has its own distinctive style of hat, often woven in silk with brightly colored geometric patterns.



Silver ornaments adorn this Turkmen girl's hat.

The Aral Sea in 1960



Fishing village on the coast

Fishing village stranded inland

The Aral Sea in 1995

The lake is about ten per cent of its original size.

SHRINKING SEA

The Aral Sea, once the fourth largest freshwater lake in the world, is shrinking. Fishing villages that once stood on the sea coast are now stranded inland, depriving villagers of their livelihood. This environmental disaster has been caused by water being drained for irrigation projects from the Amu Darya River, which flows into the Aral Sea. Huge areas of useless land have been laid bare. Wind storms are common, sweeping up polluted dust and dumping it on the surrounding countryside.